

Wedge Issue Competition: Voter Perceptions of Credibility and Issue Ownership on Climate and Immigration

Zach Dickson w/ Sara B. Hobolt

z.dickson@lse.ac.uk

<https://z-dickson.github.io/>

EPSS Belfast · June 2026



Mainstream Parties are Moving onto Challenger Turf



“Without fair immigration rules, we risk becoming an **island of strangers**”

Keir Starmer (Labour), May 2025

Labour embraces restrictive immigration policy



“Net zero by 2050 is **impossible**
... without bankrupting us”

Kemi Badenoch (Conservatives), March 2025

Conservatives abandon the climate consensus

...but Challengers Own These Issues



Reform UK

immigration



The Greens

Net Zero

*Issue entrepreneurship creates durable ownership:
voters come to see wedge issues as naturally belonging
to challenger parties*

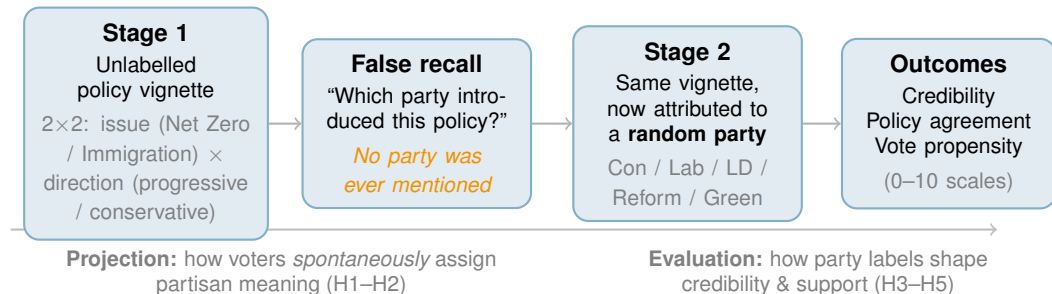
- **Can mainstream parties reclaim wedge issues? Mixed evidence:**
 - ↪ Accommodation can win voters back (*Hjorth & Larsen 2022; Spoon & Klüver 2020*)
 - ↪ ... or legitimize challengers and strengthen their appeal (*Abou-Chadi & Krause 2020; Krause et al. 2023*)
- **The open question:**
 - ↪ Existing work asks whether accommodation *pays* — not whether voters find the new position **credible**

Argument: Reclaiming Wedge Issues is a Credibility Problem

“Once a party has placed its ideology ‘on the market,’ it cannot suddenly abandon or radically alter that ideology without convincing the voters that it is unreliable” — Downs (1957)

- **Voters evaluate repositioning through two heuristics:**
 - ↪ **Ideological congruence** — does the position fit the party's broader reputation?
 - ↪ **Issue ownership** — is this party the issue's authentic advocate?
- **The implication:**
 - ↪ Mainstream parties cannot simply leapfrog established issue owners
 - ↪ Accommodation should be credible — and electorally useful — *only* within the limits of a party's existing ideological profile

Research Design: a two-stage survey experiment



- **Data:** YouGov, January 2026 · N = 6,308 British adults · nationally representative
- **Pre-registered** hypotheses, design, and analysis plan (OSF) · Bayesian estimation throughout

What Respondents Saw: Unlabelled Policy Proposals

"In British politics, political parties regularly propose alternative policies to address major issues, such as climate change or immigration. The following statement reflects a policy proposal that a party might put forward."

Net Zero (progressive direction)

"The UK should significantly intensify its efforts to reach Net Zero greenhouse gas emissions by 2050. Our policy will impose stricter environmental regulations, greater energy efficiency in homes, higher carbon pricing and expand public investment in renewable energy and green infrastructure. Our party believes that more decisive climate action is necessary to protect the environment and our country's long-term future, even if this increases short-term costs for consumers and businesses."

Immigration (restrictive direction)

"The UK should adopt stronger measures to reduce immigration and tighten border controls. Our policy will implement a far stricter immigration system that sharply reduces net immigration, blocks new arrivals from accessing benefits, and swiftly deports migrants who do not contribute economically or who breach the terms of their visa. Our party believes that only a stricter immigration policy will put the national interest first."

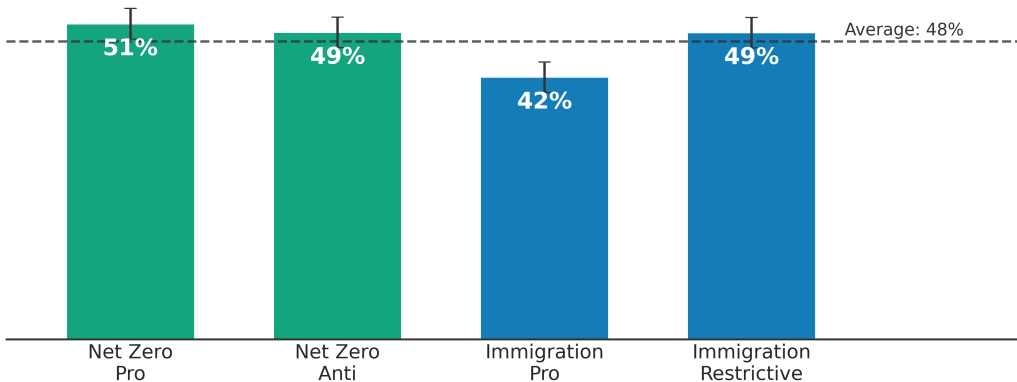
"Which party introduced this policy?" — no party was ever mentioned

Findings — Stage 1: Projection without Party Cues

- No party was ever mentioned — yet **48% of voters named one anyway.**

No party was ever mentioned — yet nearly half of voters named one anyway

Share of respondents attributing the unlabelled policy to a party, by vignette condition



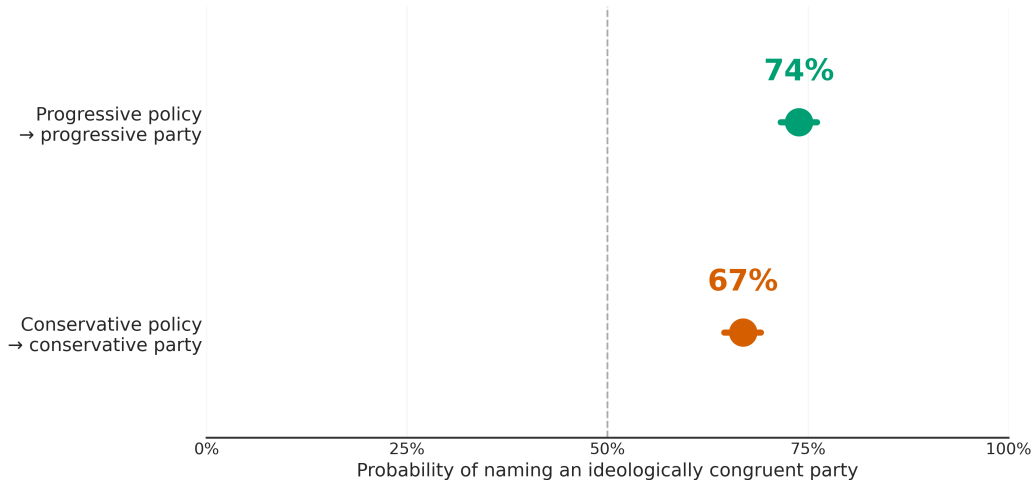
YouGov, January 2026. N = 6,308. Error bars are 95% confidence intervals.

Findings — Stage 1: Projection without Party Cues

- No party was ever mentioned — yet **48% of voters named one anyway.**
- Projection is ideological — and symmetric: progressive policies are pinned on a **progressive party (74%)**, conservative policies on a **conservative party (67%)**

Voters project the matching party — in both directions

Among those who named a party, the named party is ideologically congruent 67–74% of the time (95% HDI)



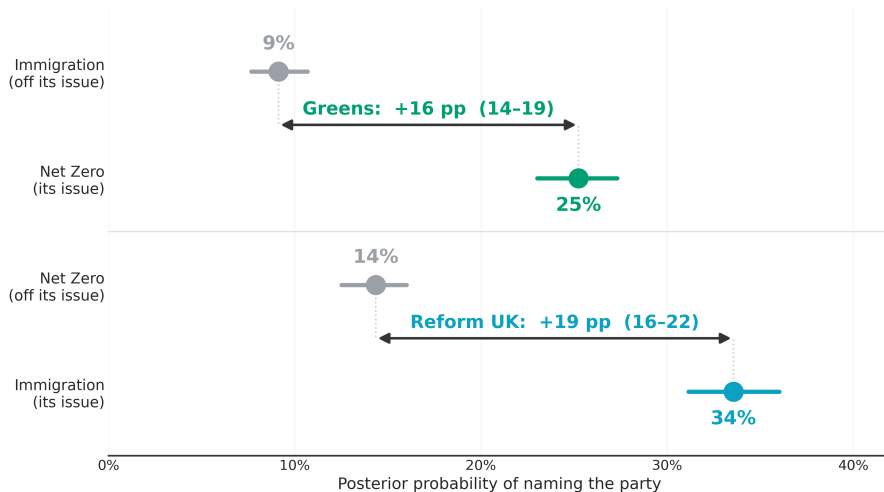
YouGov, January 2026. Respondents who named a party. Bayesian logistic regression; dots are posterior medians, intervals are 95% HDIs.

Findings — Stage 1: Projection without Party Cues

- No party was ever mentioned — yet **48% of voters named one anyway.**
- Projection is ideological — and symmetric: progressive policies are pinned on a **progressive party (74%)**, conservative policies on a **conservative party (67%)**
- Projection tracks **issue ownership**: identical proposals go to the **Greens** on Net Zero (**+16 pp**) and to **Reform UK** on immigration (**+19 pp**)

Voters credit each wedge issue to its owner

Each challenger is named far more often when the vignette is on its signature issue (95% HDI)

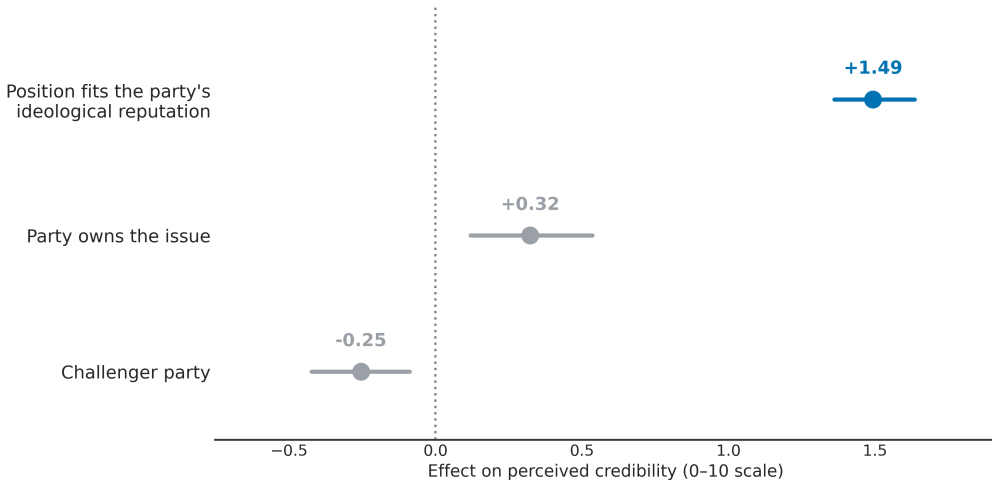


Findings — Stage 2: Evaluating Party-Labelled Policies

- Credibility hinges on **ideological congruence: +1.5 points** (0–10) when a position fits the party's reputation — issue owners gain a further +0.3

Credibility hinges on ideological fit (+1.5 points on a 0-10 scale)

Effects on how credible respondents find the party's position; posterior medians with 95% HDI

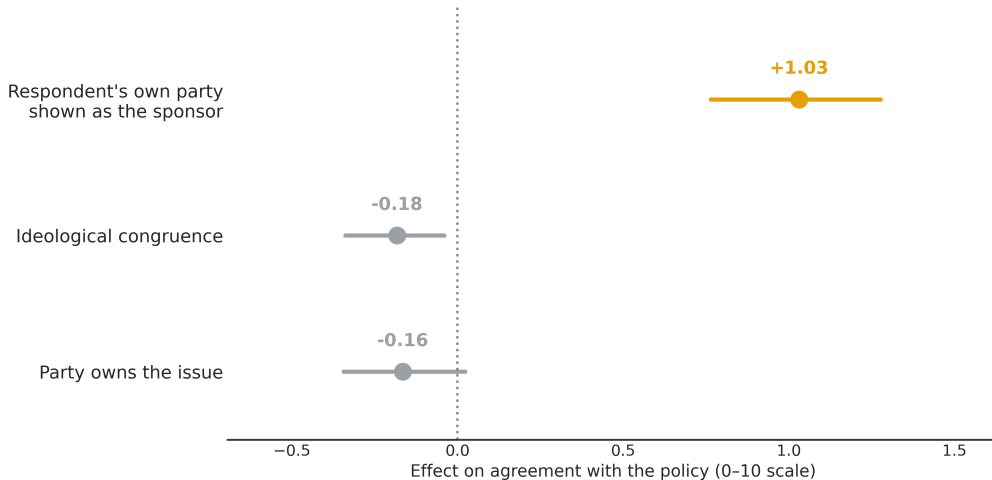


Findings — Stage 2: Evaluating Party-Labelled Policies

- Credibility hinges on **ideological congruence**: **+1.5 points** (0–10) when a position fits the party's reputation — issue owners gain a further +0.3
- Party cues still matter: **own-party** proposals gain **+1.0** agreement, regardless of content

Voters back their own party's proposal (+1.0) — whatever it says

Effects on agreement with the policy; posterior medians with 95% HDI

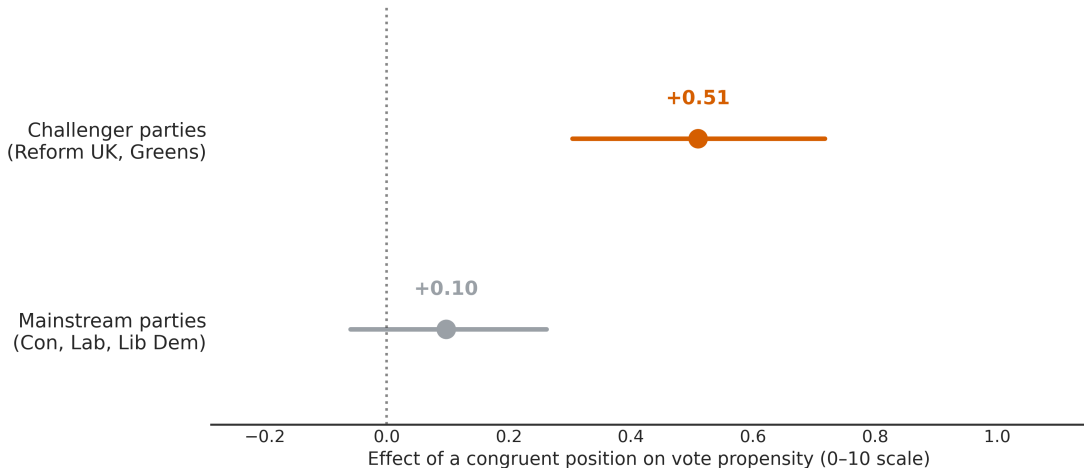


Findings — Stage 2: Evaluating Party-Labelled Policies

- Credibility hinges on **ideological congruence**: **+1.5 points** (0–10) when a position fits the party's reputation — issue owners gain a further +0.3
- Party cues still matter: **own-party** proposals gain **+1.0** agreement, regardless of content
- Electoral rewards for congruence accrue **to challengers (+0.51)** — for mainstream parties the effect is **indistinguishable from zero** (+0.10)

Only challengers reap electoral rewards from ideological congruence

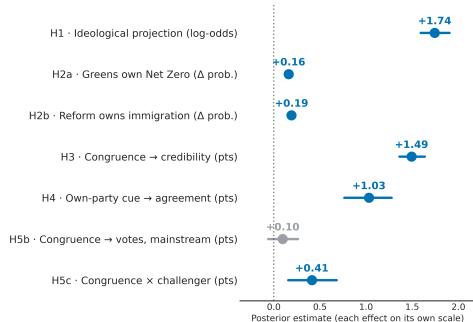
Congruence effect on vote propensity by party type; for mainstream parties it is indistinguishable from zero



Implications: The Perceptual Limits of Accommodation

Supported on every test — except electoral rewards for mainstream parties

Pre-registered effects, posterior medians with 95% HDI (gray = inconclusive)



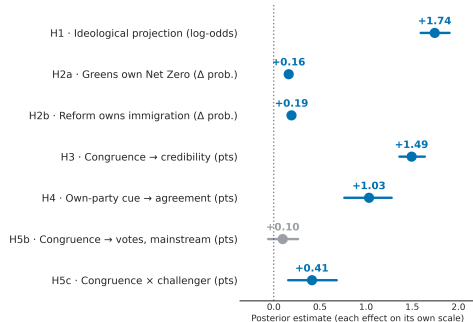
YouGov, January 2026. N = 6,308. Bayesian estimation; 4 chains × 2,000 draws.

- Reclaiming a wedge issue is fundamentally a **credibility problem**, not a positioning problem — a party cannot simply adopt a new stance and expect to inherit ownership

Implications: The Perceptual Limits of Accommodation

Supported on every test — except electoral rewards for mainstream parties

Pre-registered effects, posterior medians with 95% HDI (gray = inconclusive)



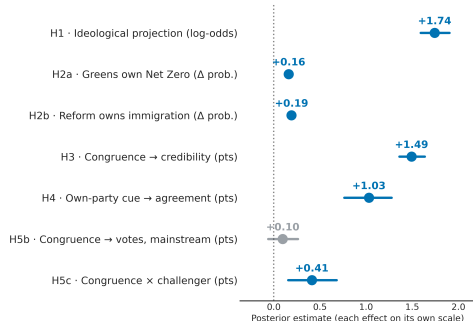
YouGov, January 2026. N = 6,308. Bayesian estimation; 4 chains × 2,000 draws.

- Reclaiming a wedge issue is fundamentally a **credibility problem**, not a positioning problem — a party cannot simply adopt a new stance and expect to inherit ownership
- The binding constraint lies **in voters' perceptions**, not party strategy: ownership and ideological reputations are the heuristics voters use to judge whether a shift is credible

Implications: The Perceptual Limits of Accommodation

Supported on every test — except electoral rewards for mainstream parties

Pre-registered effects, posterior medians with 95% HDI (gray = inconclusive)



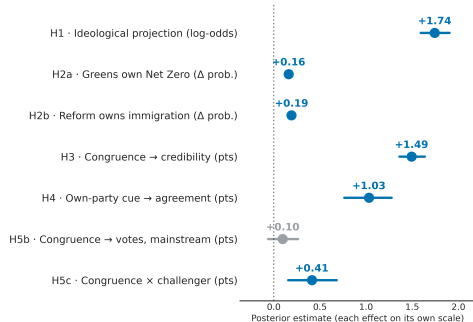
YouGov, January 2026. N = 6,308. Bayesian estimation; 4 chains × 2,000 draws.

- Reclaiming a wedge issue is fundamentally a **credibility problem**, not a positioning problem — a party cannot simply adopt a new stance and expect to inherit ownership
- The binding constraint lies **in voters' perceptions**, not party strategy: ownership and ideological reputations are the heuristics voters use to judge whether a shift is credible
- Accommodation** on wedge issues works only *within* a party's existing ideological reputation; there is no leapfrogging the issue owner

Implications: The Perceptual Limits of Accommodation

Supported on every test — except electoral rewards for mainstream parties

Pre-registered effects, posterior medians with 95% HDI (gray = inconclusive)



YouGov, January 2026. N = 6,308. Bayesian estimation; 4 chains × 2,000 draws.

- Reclaiming a wedge issue is fundamentally a **credibility problem**, not a positioning problem — a party cannot simply adopt a new stance and expect to inherit ownership
- The binding constraint lies **in voters' perceptions**, not party strategy: ownership and ideological reputations are the heuristics voters use to judge whether a shift is credible
- Accommodation** on wedge issues works only *within* a party's existing ideological reputation; there is no leapfrogging the issue owner

Zach Dickson & Sara Hobolt

**Wedge Issue Competition:
Credibility and Issue Ownership
on Climate and Immigration**



z.dickson@lse.ac.uk

Appendix & Robustness

Pre-Registered Hypothesis Tests: Summary

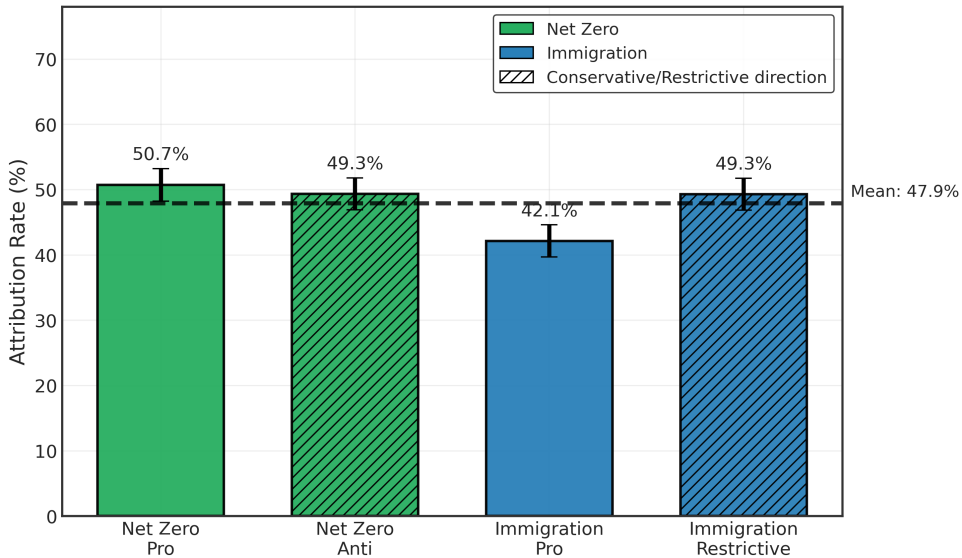
Hyp.	Predicted effect	Median [95% HDI]	Verdict
H1	Ideological projection (log-odds)	1.74 [1.59, 1.90]	Supported
H2a	Green × Net Zero (ΔP)	0.16 [0.14, 0.19]	Supported
H2b	Reform × Immigration (ΔP)	0.19 [0.16, 0.22]	Supported
H3	Credibility: congruence (pts)	1.49 [1.36, 1.63]	Supported
H4	Agreement: own party (pts)	1.03 [0.77, 1.28]	Supported
H5b	Vote: congruence, mainstream (pts)	0.10 [−0.07, 0.25]	Inconclusive
H5c	Vote: congruence × challenger (pts)	0.42 [0.15, 0.66]	Supported

$P(\beta > 0) = 1.00$ for all supported hypotheses; 0.87 for H5b. Bayesian regressions with weakly informative priors; 4 chains × 2,000 draws; $\hat{R} \approx 1.00$.

Estimating Equations and Test Quantities by Hypothesis

Hyp.	Outcome (DV)	Model	Sample	Test quantity
H1	Progressive-party attribution (0/1)	Logistic	n = 3,021	$\Delta P = \text{logit}^{-1}(\alpha + \beta) - \text{logit}^{-1}(\alpha)$
H2a	Green attribution (0/1)	Logistic	n = 3,021	$\text{logit}^{-1}(\alpha_G + \beta_G) - \text{logit}^{-1}(\alpha_G)$
H2b	Reform attribution (0/1)	Logistic	n = 3,021	$\text{logit}^{-1}(\alpha_R) - \text{logit}^{-1}(\alpha_R + \beta_R)$
H3	Credibility (0–10)	Linear	N = 6,308	β_1 (on Cong)
H4	Policy agreement (0–10)	Linear	N = 6,308	β_1 (on OwnPty)
H5b	Vote propensity (0–10)	Linear	N = 6,308	β_1 (on Cong)
H5c	Vote propensity (0–10)	Linear	N = 6,308	β_3 (on Cong $\times$ Chal); chall. = $\beta_1 + \beta_3$
H5a	Vote propensity (0–10)	Linear	N = 6,308	γ (on VoterCong)

“Test quantity” is the posterior summary that formally tests each hypothesis. For H1/H2 it is a derived difference in predicted probabilities, not a raw log-odds coefficient. H5a is the supplementary voter-level congruence model.

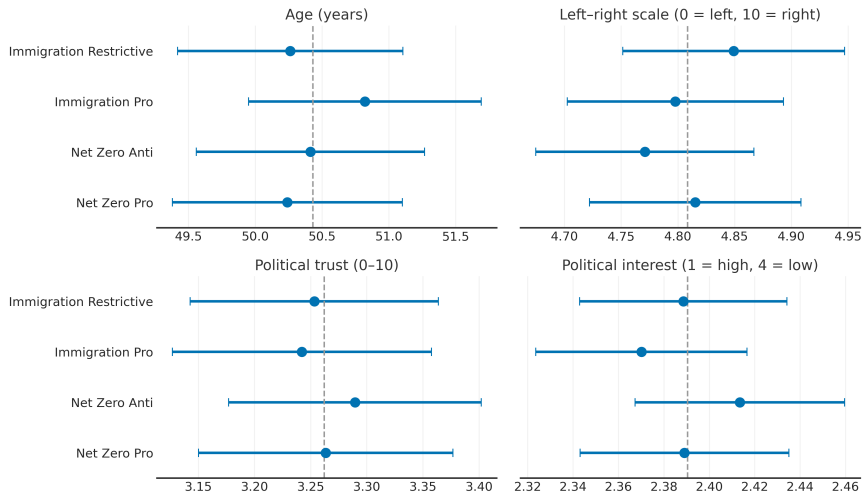


Attribution Rates Are Balanced Across Conditions

- 52.1% of respondents correctly selected “None of the above / not mentioned”
- Attribution rates range **44.4%–52.0%** across the four vignette conditions
 - ↔ No systematic difference by policy direction or issue type — the sub-sample of attributors used for H1–H2 is not selectively biased by treatment assignment

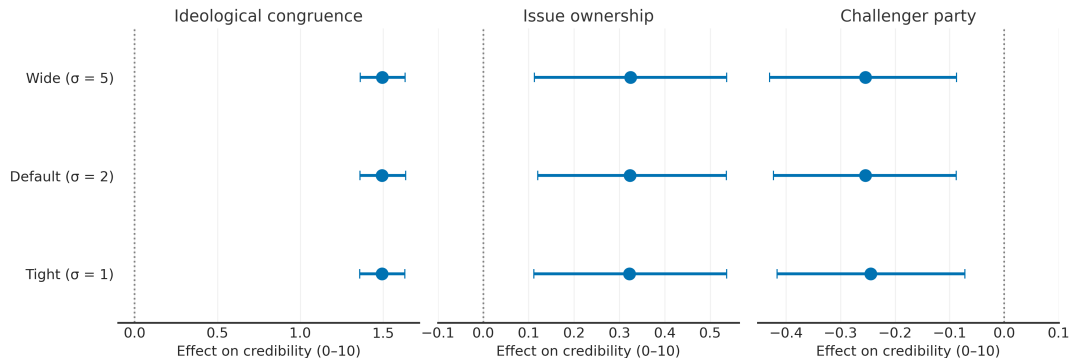
Randomisation worked: the four vignette groups look alike

Group means of pre-treatment covariates ($\pm 95\%$ CI); dashed line marks the full-sample mean



The findings do not depend on the choice of priors

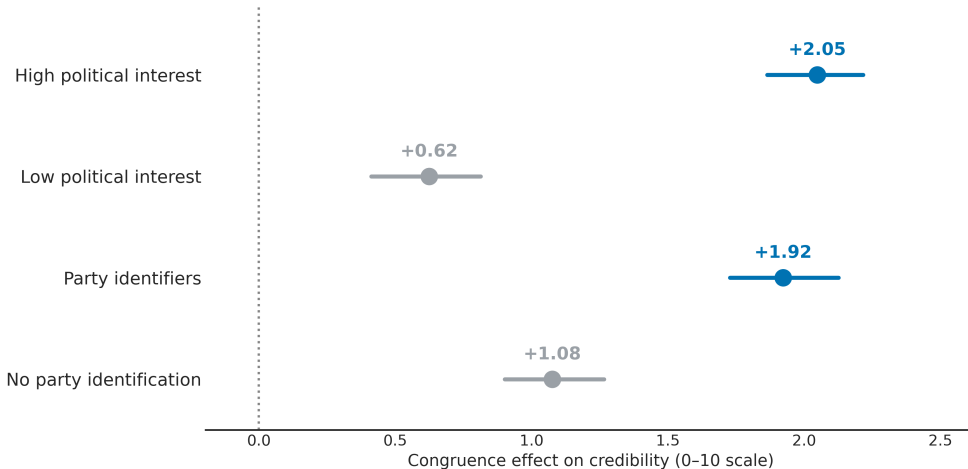
H3 credibility model re-estimated under tight, default and wide priors (95% HDI)



Posterior medians with 95% highest-density intervals.

Voters who know the parties best police credibility hardest

Congruence effect on perceived credibility, estimated separately within subgroups (95% HDI)



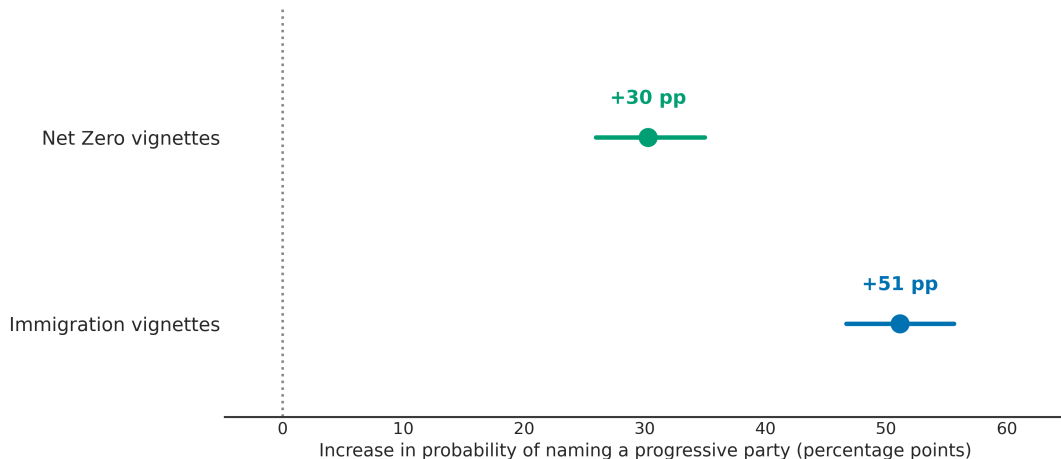
YouGov, January 2026. Separate Bayesian regressions per subgroup; medians with 95% highest-density intervals.

Heterogeneity: Credibility Judgements Are Political

- The congruence effect on credibility is **3× larger** among high-interest respondents (2.04 vs. 0.62) and **2× larger** among party identifiers (1.91 vs. 1.07)
 - ↪ Consistent with the heuristics account: voters who know the parties' reputations best are the ones who police credibility most strongly

Ideological projection appears on both wedge issues

Effect of showing a progressive (vs conservative) policy on naming a progressive party, by issue (95% HDI)



YouGov, January 2026. Respondents who named a party; separate Bayesian logistic regressions per issue.

Voters reward positions that match their own views (+1.5 points)

Extended vote-propensity model; posterior medians with 95% HDI

